

Reading into Writing – Gender

What are gender stereotypes and why do they persist?

Extract One:

Prentice, D. A., & Carranza, E. (2002). What women and men should be, shouldn't be, are allowed to be, and don't have to be: The contents of prescriptive gender stereotypes. *Psychology of women quarterly*, 26(4), 269-281.

Gender stereotypes are highly prescriptive. The qualities they ascribe to women and men tend also to be ones that are required of women and men. For example, the stereotypic belief that women are warm and caring is matched by a societal prescription that they should be warm and caring. Similarly, the stereotypic belief that men are strong and agentic is matched by a societal prescription that they should be strong and agentic. Recent interest in the prescriptive aspect of gender stereotypes has been sparked by two observations: First, gender stereotypes are closely linked to traditional social roles and power inequalities between women and men (Eagly, 1987). A number of researchers have traced this link to the prescriptive component of gender stereotypes and its role in justifying and perpetuating the status quo (Hoffman & Hurst, 1990; Jost & Banaji, 1994; Sidanius & Pratto, 1999). Second, violations of gender stereotypes are met with various forms of punishment and devaluation, many of which appear to stem from their prescriptive quality (Fiske, Bersoff, Borgida, Deaux, & Heilman, 1991; Rudman & Glick, 1999). Indeed, the distinction between the descriptive and prescriptive components of gender stereotypes has proven quite useful for analyzing real-world cases of sexual harassment and sex discrimination (Burgess & Borgida, 1999).

Of course, interest in prescriptive gender stereotypes among social psychologists is nothing new; almost three decades ago, early studies of sex-role identity provided an initial look at the contents of these stereotypes (Bem, 1974). The studies were designed to develop a trait-based measure of individual differences in the internalization of societal gender prescriptions; as a by-product, they documented the contents of those

prescriptions. Bem (1974) asked male and female participants to rate each of a large pool of traits in terms of its desirability for a woman or its desirability for a man. In both cases, she asked them to make these ratings according to what society deemed desirable, rather than according to their own personal opinions. She categorized as feminine traits rated as significantly more desirable for a woman than for a man by both male and female participants; she categorized as masculine traits rated as significantly more desirable for a man than for a woman by both male and female participants. These criteria yielded the 20 feminine and 20 masculine characteristics that appear on the Bem Sex Role Inventory (BSRI; see Bem, 1981 for a review). Feminine characteristics are: affectionate, cheerful, childlike, compassionate, does not use harsh language, eager to soothe hurt feelings, feminine, flatterable, gentle, gullible, loves children, loyal, sensitive to the needs of others, shy, soft-spoken, sympathetic, tender, understanding, warm, and yielding. Masculine characteristics are: acts as a leader, aggressive, ambitious, analytical, assertive, athletic, competitive, defends own beliefs, dominant, forceful, has leadership abilities, independent, individualistic, makes decisions easily, masculine, self-reliant, self-sufficient, strong personality, willing to take a stand, and willing to take risks. These characteristics provide a good representation of prescriptive gender stereotypes, at least as they existed in the early 1970s.

Extract Two:

Ellemers, N. (2018). Gender stereotypes. *Annual review of psychology*, 69(1), 275-298.

How are gender stereotypes communicated? This mostly happens implicitly, through the way we speak about and portray the activities, desires, and achievements of men and women. In educating their children, parents may implicitly teach them what (in)appropriate behaviours for women and men are. Even parents who consciously treat their sons and daughters equally communicate these implicit expectations, for instance, when reading a picture book with their children. They convey what they consider to be appropriate behaviours and activities for boys and girls by making more positive comments about images of children engaging in gender-stereotypical activities (Endendijk et al. 2014).

Media representations also reinforce stereotypical expectations of men and women by primarily showing men in expert roles and women in caregiving roles in advertisements, TV series, and news programs or by printing photographs portraying the face and upper torso of men while providing full-body images of women, which facilitates the tendency to evaluate women on the basis of their dress style and body shape (Matthews 2007). Likewise, media coverage of public figures focuses on the achievements of men while addressing the appearance or personal relationships of women. These portrayals are not without consequences. In fact, over time, the gender stereotypes implicitly conveyed in this way impact the beliefs that girls develop about gender roles, their bodies, and sexual relationships (Ward & Harrison 2005).

The verbal accounts we provide and receive about the behaviours of others and ourselves also implicitly convey and reinforce gender-stereotypical expectations. Linguistic biases can have far-reaching implications, as was revealed by an analysis of 1,244 recommendation letters from 54 countries, submitted to support postdoctoral researchers in the geosciences. Across the board, female applicants were significantly less likely to be described as “excellent” by those who were supporting them, regardless of whether the

recommendations were made by men or women (Dutt et al. 2016). Likewise, recommendations for applicants for an academic faculty position were more likely to contain “standout” (excellent, outstanding, exceptional) and “ability” (talent, genius, brilliant) words for male candidates, whereas “grindstone” words (hardworking, conscientious, dependable) were chosen to praise the abilities of female candidates (Schmader et al. 2007).

Non-verbal communications, particularly body posture, may also implicitly convey and reinforce gender stereotypes. In public situations, men and women adopt different body postures, with men displaying more expansive and open postures (occupying physical space), whereas women are more likely to show closed and contractive postures (crossed arms and legs) (Cashdan 1998). Male and female dress styles, the differential body size of men and women, and childhood socialization about proper demeanour for girls and boys all contribute to these differences. The implicit activation of gender stereotypes also leads women to adopt more contractive body postures (De Lemus et al. 2012). Open and expansive body postures also relate to dominance and high power, whereas closed and contractive body postures indicate submission and low power. Such postures convey information to others but also affect the way people perceive and present themselves (Carney et al. 2010).

Finally, the emotions expressed by men and women also reinforce gender stereotypical expectations. Research suggests that men and women have similar emotional experiences. However, the way they communicate about their emotions is different, with men expressing all negative emotions as anger—related to action and agency—and women more likely to indicate sadness—associated with lack of control (Plant et al. 2000).

Extract Three:

Haines, E. L., Deaux, K., & Lofaro, N. (2016). The times they are a-changing... or are they not? A comparison of gender stereotypes, 1983–2014. *Psychology of Women Quarterly*, 40(3), 353–363.

Deaux and Lewis (1983) reported strong stereotypes of women and men—not only for traits but also for social roles, occupations, and physical characteristics. In the current study, we continued to find strong stereotyping and a great deal of consistency with the stereotyping reported in the past. Despite differences in samples and in time periods, there was virtually no difference in the degree to which beliefs about typical men and women were differentiated on agentic and communal traits, male gender roles, male and female occupations, and male and female physical characteristics.

We entertained competing predictions regarding changes in stereotypes over time. According to Social Representations Theory (Eagly, 1987), we would expect that the real changes in men's and women's occupation of roles in the home, workplace, and in sports would produce a lessening of gender stereotypes today as compared to the past, particularly for women (Croft et al., 2015). But we did not find evidence of substantial stereotype change, in spite of the societal changes and even though attitudes toward male and female roles have become less traditional over time (Spence & Hahn, 1997; Twenge, 1997a).

Theories that emphasize processes of confirmation bias and self-fulfilling prophecies provide greater support for our findings of little change in gender stereotyping. Given the extensive use of gender categories and the seeming utility of differentiating between women and men, people may be resistant to changing their stereotypes to any significant degree. The ease with which people are able to confirm gender stereotypes by selectively finding consistent exemplars (e.g., Rothbart & Park, 1986) contribute to stereotype stability and maintenance. Further, even when women are making choices inconsistent with their expected roles, backlash and status incongruity theory (Rudman et al., 2012; Rudman & Glick, 2001) suggest that the women will engage in behaviours that are stereotype-consistent in order to avoid negative evaluations.

Also consistent with our findings is evidence for the high degree of essentialism in beliefs about gender (Croft et al., 2015; Prentice & Miller, 2007). To the extent that people believe that the basic characteristics of women and men are inherent to the category, then

evidence of more peripheral changes in behaviours is unlikely to shape beliefs in the basic attributes. Suggestions of a cultural lag between societal changes and gender beliefs (Diekmann et al., 2010) are also consistent with the stability that we observed.

In summary, there appears to be more support for stereotype maintenance via confirmation bias, cultural lag, backlash, and essentialist categorical beliefs, despite the movement toward more similar roles and behaviours between men and women.